the picture. He has even stopped media interactions, though BSP functionaries claim "he is still in the party". Most of the other Brahmin leaders, including Nakul Dubey, Rakesh Pandey, etc. have also left the party.

Political observers feel Behenji's lack of trust in her leaders will lead to more churn in the BSP. Dr Shilp Shikha Singh, assistant professor at Lucknow's Giri Institute of Development Studies, says, "The BSP was strongest when it was able to top up its core Dalit vote with that of Brahmins and smaller OBC communities along with Muslims. The first two have multiple choices now and are unlikely to return, so the disoriented Muslims look like the safest bet. But will they prefer BSP over SP and Congress in 2024? Also, Mayawati's strategy now seems directed more at damaging the SP than the BJP. Which is why critics are asking who her real target is. She is sending confusing signals right now."

In the past 6-7 years, many of the BSP's top leaders have left or were expelled. In 2016, Brajesh Pathak, now a deputy CM in the state, was expelled for "anti-party activities". Pathak later went public on the "corruption and anarchy" in the BSP. Then, after the 2017 assembly polls, Mayawati expelled another close aide and the party's Muslim face, Naseemuddin Siddiqui, on similar charges. Other key leaders, like Brijlal Khabri, Lalji Verma and Ram Achal Rajbhar, too, left the party in the intervening years. Masood, who was the Congress's minority face in west UP for over a decade, now takes over after an unhappy stint in the SP. He is the new BSP coordinator for western UP and Uttarakhand and feels that Muslim voters will prefer the party in 2024 as they have "already tested [SP chief] Akhilesh Yadav in 2022 and seen that he can't defeat the BJP".

Meanwhile, Mayawati's nephew and BSP national coordinator Akash Anand seems to be active everywhere else except in UP. Behenji being the only "authorised voice" of the BSP, no one knows what her plans for him are either. As a former BSP MLA says on condition of anonymity, "*Behenji ki maya Behenji hi jaanein* (Only Mayawati knows what she's doing)." For a party that was ruling UP just a decade back, the fall has been precipitous. ■

MADHYA PRADESH

THE GREAT TRIBAL OUTREACH

By Rahul Noronha

It's not for nothing that the BJP government in Madhya Pradesh is on a massive tribal outreach—the assembly election is just a year away. And, with a 21 per cent tribal population as per the 2011 census, MP has the highest number of people from Adivasi communities among all states. However, in 2018, the BJP had won only 16 of the 47 seats reserved for Scheduled Tribes (ST) whereas the Congress had bagged 30 and one seat had gone to an Independent. Even as the number of seats with the Congress has reduced owing to a couple of defeats in by-elections, the party still holds a majority of them in the 230-member assembly. The criticality of the tribal vote to electoral victory can be gauged from the fact that in 2013, when the BJP won in the state, the party had bagged 31 of these 47 seats.

On November 15, President Droupadi Murmu was in Shahdol in eastern MP—her maiden visit to the state after being sworn in as the head of state—to participate in a function held to mark Janjatiya Gaurav Diwas, or Tribal Pride Day. (Last year, the Union government had declared the birth anniversary of tribal icon Birsa Munda as Janjatiya Gaurav Diwas.) Her visit comes at a time when the ruling BJP has been pulling out all the stops to win back the tribal vote ahead of the 2023 election. And the occasion was used to launch a big-ticket pro-tribal programme—the formulation of Rules under the Panchayat Extension to Scheduled Areas (PESA) Act—that had been in the pipeline for long. Announced by the President, Notification of Rules under PESA will enable the implementation of the Act in the state, making it the eighth one in the country to do so. The PESA Act vests power with the panchayat gram sabhas to take decisions on a host of subjects. The legislation will be applicable in the 89 tribal blocks—nearly a quarter of the state's 333 development blocks, and just a little less than a third of its total area.

THE PESA ACT EMPOWERS THE GRAM SABHAS ON ISSUES OF MINOR FOREST PRODUCE COLLECTION AND DISPUTE-RESOLUTION IN MINING AND EXCISE

The formulation of the Rules was a complicated affair given that the move, while being pro-tribal and empowering the gram sabha, could alienate certain other groups living in scheduled areas, mostly OBCs, who have stood by the BJP through the years. The fact that the Rules came 26 years after the PESA Act was passed also suggests that the state's Congress government, from 1993 to